POWER BI

If I Had a Power BI Interview Tomorrow With Only 3 Hours

A 3-hour plan: what to revise in each hour, with the exact answers and DAX to have ready. Built around what Power BI interviews actually ask.

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The 3-hour plan

Do it in this order. Hour 1 covers the questions asked in almost every round.

- **Hour 1: Data model and DAX basics**
  Star schema, relationships, measures vs columns, CALCULATE.
- **Hour 2: Time intelligence and common measures**
  YoY, YTD, % of total, ranking. Write them, do not just read them.
- **Hour 3: Service, performance and your project**
  RLS, refresh, slow reports, and your 2-minute dashboard story.

Rule: in each hour, spend half the time reading and half saying the answers out loud.

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Hour 1: Model answers

Have a one-line answer for each.

Star schema

A fact table of events (sales) in the middle, dimension tables (date, product, customer) around it, one-to-many relationships.

Why a Date table

Time intelligence needs a continuous date column marked as a date table.

Measure vs calculated column

Column: row by row at refresh, stored, used to slice.
Measure: at query time, used for totals.

Filter vs row context

Row context is the current row in an iteration. Filter context is what slicers, visuals and CALCULATE filter.

What CALCULATE does

Changes the filter context, then evaluates the expression.

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Hour 1: DAX to write

Write each one from memory. Then check.

```
Total Sales = SUM(Sales[Amount])

Sales North =
CALCULATE([Total Sales], Region[Name] = "North")

Sales All Regions =
CALCULATE([Total Sales], ALL(Region))

Revenue = SUMX(Sales, Sales[Qty] * Sales[Price])
```

SUM vs SUMX

SUMX goes row by row first. Needed when you multiply columns.

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Hour 2: Measures they ask for

These 5 come up in most practical rounds.

```
% of Total =
DIVIDE([Total Sales], CALCULATE([Total Sales],
ALL(Product)))

Sales LY =
CALCULATE([Total Sales],
SAMEPERIODLASTYEAR('Date'[Date]))

YoY % = DIVIDE([Total Sales] - [Sales LY],
[Sales LY])

Sales YTD = TOTALYTD([Total Sales],
'Date'[Date])

Product Rank =
RANKX(ALL(Product[Name]), [Total Sales], , DESC)
```

Why DIVIDE

Returns blank instead of an error when the denominator is 0.

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Hour 3: Service and performance

These separate people who have used Power BI at work from those who have only built in Desktop.

Row Level Security

Create roles in Desktop with a DAX filter, assign users to roles in the Service.

Import vs DirectQuery

Import: fast, data copied, scheduled refresh.
DirectQuery: live, slower, for very large or real-time data.

Refresh and gateway

Scheduled refresh in the Service. A gateway is needed when the data source is on-premises.

Slow report fixes

Use Performance Analyzer, reduce visuals per page, remove unused columns, prefer measures to calculated columns, keep a star schema.

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Hour 3: Your project story

Almost every interview ends with "walk me through a dashboard you built". Prepare this.

- **The business question**

  "Sales heads could not see which regions were missing target until month end."

- **The data and model**

  Sources, how you cleaned them in Power Query, your star schema.

- **2 measures you wrote**

  Explain one simple and one with CALCULATE or time intelligence.

- **The impact**

  "Managers now check daily. Weekly review prep dropped from 4 hours to 30 minutes."

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Last 10 minutes

Before you log in or walk in.

- **Open Power BI Desktop**

  If there is a live task, you do not want to wait for it to load.

- **Have a sample file ready**

  Any sales dataset, in case they ask you to build something quickly.

- **Say your project story once**

  Out loud, in under 2 minutes.

- **Prepare 2 questions for them**

  What data sources the team uses, and how reports are used in decisions.

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